

HAITNER FAMILY JOURNEY



ITINERARY · FOOD · CULTURE · PARKS

Japan 2026

Twenty-five days across Tokyo, Hakone, Kyoto, Hiroshima, and Osaka — designed for first-timers who love food, culture, and amusement parks.

DATES

Sep 1 – 25

DAYS

25

REGIONS

5

NIGHTS

24

Trip at a Glance

An expanded first-timer route: more Tokyo to settle in, classic Kyoto temples including the Golden Pavilion, Hiroshima’s remembrance and Miyajima, Osaka’s food and Universal Studios, then a Tokyo finale with sumo season potential.

	TOKYO	→ HAKONE	→ KYOTO	→ HIROSHIMA	→ OSAKA	→ TOKYO
#	DATE	DAY	CITY	FOCUS		
Day 01	September 1	Tue	TOKYO	Touchdown in Tokyo		
Day 02	September 2	Wed	TOKYO	Shibuya, Meiji Shrine & Harajuku		
Day 03	September 3	Thu	TOKYO	Tokyo DisneySea — full park day		
Day 04	September 4	Fri	TOKYO	Asakusa, Kappabashi & Skytree		
Day 05	September 5	Sat	TOKYO	Tsukiji breakfast, palace & Ginza		
Day 06	September 6	Sun	TOKYO	teamLab Planets & Odaiba		
Day 07	September 7	Mon	TOKYO	Ueno, Akihabara & Golden Gai		
Day 08	September 8	Tue	TOKYO	Daikanyama, Nakameguro & New York Bar		
Day 09	September 9	Wed	HAKONE	Onsen country — art, volcano & Lake Ashi		
Day 10	September 10	Thu	KYOTO	Arrive Kyoto — markets, Gion & Pontocho		
Day 11	September 11	Fri	KYOTO	Arashiyama bamboo & temples		
Day 12	September 12	Sat	KYOTO	Fushimi Inari, Uji & tea ceremony		
Day 13	September 13	Sun	KYOTO	Higashiyama — stone streets & temples		
Day 14	September 14	Mon	KYOTO	Golden Pavilion & classic north Kyoto		
Day 15	September 15	Tue	HIROSHIMA	Hiroshima — garden calm & Peace Memorial		
Day 16	September 16	Wed	HIROSHIMA	Miyajima Island day		
Day 17	September 17	Thu	OSAKA	Osaka arrival — markets, castle, neon		
Day 18	September 18	Fri	OSAKA	Universal Studios Japan		
Day 19	September 19	Sat	OSAKA	Nara deer park & Shinsekai		
Day 20	September 20	Sun	OSAKA	Arcade shopping & Umeda views		
Day 21	September 21	Mon	OSAKA	Osaka food & culture deep dive		
Day 22	September 22	Tue	TOKYO	Return to Tokyo — Ginza ease		
Day 23	September 23	Wed	TOKYO	Sumo culture day (Aki basho season)		
Day 24	September 24	Thu	TOKYO	Last full day — favorites & shopping		
Day 25	September 25	Fri	TOKYO	Tsukiji morning & Narita departure		

New & Must-See Highlights

Additions beyond the original spreadsheet — chosen for first-time visitors who want iconic culture, great food, and park days.

Tokyo DisneySea

UNIQUE-TO-JAPAN DISNEY PARK

teamLab Planets

IMMERSIVE ART MUST-DO

Universal Studios Japan

NINTENDO WORLD & COASTERS

Kinkaku-ji

GOLDEN PAVILION CLASSIC

Grand Sumo (Sep)

CULTURAL BUCKET-LIST IF TICKETS ALLOW

Food trail

TSUKIJI, NISHIKI, KUROMON, DOTONBORI

How to use this guide

- Each day lists the plan, transport steps, and recommendations — follow the order, or swap blocks if weather/energy shifts.
- Badges mark Must-see, Food, Culture, and Park moments so you can prioritize quickly.
- Food ribbons highlight what to eat that day without turning every stop into a restaurant list.

Hotels & Practical Notes

Same hotel logic as your plan, shifted to Sep 1–25. Confirm exact nightly blocks when you rebook.

TOKYO (FIRST STAY)

Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

Sep 1–9 · Shinjuku

HAKONE

Hotel Kajikaso

Sep 9–10 · Hakone–Yumoto area

KYOTO

Hotel Musse Kyoto Shijo-Kawaramachi Meitetsu

Sep 10–15 · Kawaramachi

HIROSHIMA

Daiwa Roynet Hotel Hiroshima

Sep 15–17 · Central Hiroshima

OSAKA

Cross Hotel Osaka

Sep 17–22 · Namba / Dotonbori

TOKYO (RETURN)

Solaria Nishitetsu Hotel

Sep 22–25 · Ginza area

Before you go

- Bring passports for tax-free shopping (usually ¥5,000+ at participating stores).
- Comfortable walking shoes are essential almost every day.
- Use luggage forwarding (takkyubin) between cities — especially Tokyo→Kyoto and Kyoto→Osaka.
- Book timed tickets early: DisneySea, teamLab Planets, Universal Studios, and sumo if available.
- September can be warm and rainy; pack a light rain jacket and portable charger.

TOKYO

Touchdown in Tokyo

Land at Narita, private transfer to Shinjuku, and ease into Japan with a gentle first evening.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Early dinner near the hotel — try a simple ramen shop or conveyor-belt sushi to keep it easy after the flight.

ITINERARY

01 Narita Airport Arrival

Private transfer · ~1h 30m

A driver meets you at the airport and takes you to Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo in Shinjuku. After check-in, keep the evening light so jet lag does not win.

02 Shinjuku Evening Stroll

Godzilla · neon · first bites

Wander Shinjuku's shopping streets, spot the Godzilla statue, and feel the city's energy without a packed agenda. Perfect first taste of Tokyo's scale and nightlife glow.

FOOD

➤ GETTING AROUND

- 1 Airport → hotel: private driver pickup (~1h 30m).
- 2 Stay near the hotel this evening — no long transit needed.

! RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Treat today as jet-lag recovery — early dinner, early sleep.
- ◆ Buy a Suica/Pasmo (or use iPhone Suica) for trains tomorrow.
- ◆ Convenience stores (7-Eleven, Lawson) are excellent for water, snacks, and SIM/eSIM top-ups.

TOKYO

Shibuya, Meiji Shrine & Harajuku

Tokyo icons in one walkable arc: the scramble crossing, a forest shrine, Takeshita Street, Cat Street, and Omotesando.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Harajuku crepes on Takeshita; later, café-hop on Omotesando or Cat Street.

ITINERARY

01

Shibuya Crossing

Scramble · Hachiko · Hikarie view

Cross the famous scramble, meet Hachiko, then ride up Shibuya Hikarie for a free 11th-floor view over the intersection. Miyashita Park is a good rest/shopping pause.

MUST-SEE

02

Meiji Jingu

Forest shrine in the city

One of Japan's great Shinto shrines, wrapped in quiet woodland. Write a wish on an ema plaque. On some days you may see a traditional wedding procession.

CULTURE

03

Takeshita Street & Cat Street

Harajuku youth culture

Takeshita is colorful, crowded, and crepe-famous. Cat Street is calmer and more stylish — today's Harajuku fashion energy lives here.

FOOD

04

Omotesando

Tokyo's tree-lined avenue

Elegant boutiques, architecture, and cafés along a shaded avenue often called Tokyo's Champs-Élysées. A grown-up contrast to Takeshita Street.

>

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Shibuya (~20m): Yamanote Line to Shibuya.

2

Shibuya → Meiji Shrine (~15m): Yamanote to Yoyogi, then walk.

3

Meiji → Takeshita (~10m walk); Cat Street (~5–10m more).

4

Return via Harajuku Station → Shinjuku (~30m).

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Lots of walking — schedule café breaks.

◆

Bring passports for tax-free shopping (usually ¥5,000+).

◆

If jet lag hits, you are close enough to return to the hotel midday.

TOKYO

Tokyo DisneySea — full park day

A full day at DisneySea — Japan’s unique ocean-adventure Disney park and a highlight for amusement-park lovers.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Park dining is part of the fun — book popular restaurants early in the app if you can.

ITINERARY

01 Tokyo DisneySea

PARK

Full day · rope drop recommended

DisneySea is unique to Japan — Mediterranean Harbor, Mysterious Island, Mermaid Lagoon, and more. Arrive for opening, use the official app for waits, and prioritize must-do rides first.

02 Evening return to Shinjuku

Easy night after a long park day

If energy remains, a casual late ramen near the hotel is perfect. Otherwise, rest — tomorrow is culture and temples.

➤ GETTING AROUND

- 1 Typical route: JR to Maihama / Resort Gateway, then Disney Resort Line.
- 2 Allow buffer both ways — park days run long.

! RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Buy dated tickets in advance.
- ◆ Comfortable shoes, portable charger, sunscreen, light rain layer.
- ◆ Consider Disney Premier Access for 1–2 top rides if waits look brutal.

TOKYO

Asakusa, Kappabashi & Skytree

Old Tokyo's temple heart, kitchen-town souvenirs, and Japan's tallest tower.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Nakamise snacks, melon pan, and Asakusa classics — try Hatoya, Benizuru Pancake, or Fruits Parlor Gotō.

ITINERARY

01

Asakusa & Senso-ji

Kaminarimon · Nakamise · Kannon temple

Start at the Asakusa Culture Tourist Information Center (Kengo Kuma design, 8th-floor view), walk Nakamise shopping street, then visit vivid Senso-ji — Tokyo's most beloved temple.

MUST-SEE

02

Kappabashi Street

Kitchen town

Nearly 1 km of chef-supply shops: knives, cookware, plastic food samples, lanterns. Excellent practical souvenirs for food lovers.

FOOD

03

Tokyo Skytree & Solamachi

634m views

Observation decks at 350m / 450m. Clear days may reveal Mt. Fuji. Shop and eat in Solamachi at the base.

MUST-SEE

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Asakusa (~35–45m): subway via Asakusa Line / transfers.

2

Senso-ji → Kappabashi: ~10m walk.

3

Kappabashi → Skytree (~25m): Tobu Skytree Line.

4

Return to Shinjuku by subway/JR (~40–50m).

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Senso-ji is busiest ~16:00–18:30 — earlier is calmer.

◆

Buy a quality kitchen knife at Kappabashi if you want one keepsake.

◆

Book Skytree tickets online to skip some queues.

TOKYO

Tsukiji breakfast, palace & Ginza

A food-first morning at Tsukiji Outer Market, then Imperial Palace gardens and polished Ginza shopping.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Tsukiji breakfast is the main event — tamagoyaki, grilled seafood, fresh sashimi bowls.

ITINERARY

01 Tsukiji Outer Market

Tokyo's legendary food stroll

The outer market remains one of Tokyo's best breakfast experiences. Graze stall to stall — egg omelets, seafood bowls, grilled scallops — before the day crowds thicken.

FOOD

02 Imperial Palace East Gardens

Quiet green heart of the capital

Free gardens on the former castle grounds — moats, walls, lawns, and a calm contrast to central Tokyo. Pair with a Marunouchi café stop afterward.

CULTURE

03 Marunouchi & Ginza

Elegant shopping streets

Shin-Marunouchi Building, Nakadori Avenue, then Ginza: Uniqlo flagship, GINZA SIX, Mitsukoshi rooftop terrace, Ginza Loft, and Kabuki-za. Architecture itself is part of the fun.

➤ GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Tsukiji (~35–40m by subway).

2

Tsukiji → Imperial Palace East Gardens: walk / short subway.

3

Palace area → Ginza: easy walk via Marunouchi.

4

Return to Shinjuku by subway/JR.

! RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Arrive Tsukiji early (before 9:00) for the best energy.

◆

Passport for tax-free Ginza shopping.

◆

Keep the afternoon flexible — this is a rich but walkable day.

TOKYO

teamLab Planets & Odaiba

Immersive digital art, then futuristic waterfront fun — Gundam, malls, and optional indoor rides.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Odaiba has everything from ramen to dessert museums — DiverCity and Aqua City are easy food bases.

ITINERARY

01

teamLab Planets Tokyo

Barefoot immersive art world

Walk through water, mirrors, and light installations. Timed tickets sell out — book ahead. One of the most memorable modern-Japan experiences for first-timers.

MUST-SEE

02

Odaiba Waterfront

Gundam · DiverCity · bay views

See the life-size Gundam at DiverCity, wander waterfront malls, and soak up the man-made island vibe. Optional: Tokyo Joypolis indoor amusement park if you still want rides.

PARK

➤

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → teamLab Planets (Toyosu area): ~40–50m by subway.

2

Planets → Odaiba: Yurikamome or Rinkai Line (~15–25m).

3

Return to Shinjuku via Rinkai/JR or subway (~45–60m).

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Book teamLab Planets weeks ahead if possible.

◆

Wear clothes you can roll up — some rooms involve water.

◆

Joypolis is optional; skip if the day already feels full.

TOKYO

Ueno, Akihabara & Golden Gai

Market grazing in Ameyoko, pop culture in Akihabara, tiny bars in Golden Gai.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Arrive Ameyoko hungry. Pre-Golden Gai dinner idea: Yakitori Izakaya Gekibutori.

ITINERARY

01

Ameyoko Market (Ueno)

Street-food market under the tracks

Lively stalls between Okachimachi and Ueno — seafood skewers, fruit, snacks, and market chaos in the best way. Most shops roughly 10:00–20:00.

FOOD

02

Ueno Park (optional add-on)

Museums & temple pause

If you want culture between snacks: Ueno Park holds major museums and shrines. Even a short stroll resets the pace before Akihabara.

CULTURE

03

Akihabara Electric Town

Arcades · anime · maid cafés

Electronics, gaming, and otaku culture. Try GiGO / TAITO / Namco arcades. For a playful stop: @home café or Maidreamin — funny even for one coffee.

PARK

04

Golden Gai Night Out

Shinjuku's tiny bar maze

Dozens of microscopic bars with unique personalities. Enter one or two, order a drink, and enjoy the intimate Tokyo nightlife classic.

MUST-SEE

➤

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Ameyoko (~40m): Yamanote to Okachimachi.

2

Ameyoko → Akihabara (~15m): Yamanote.

3

Akihabara → hotel (~45m), then walk ~15m to Golden Gai.

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Some Golden Gai bars are Japanese-only or regulars-only — just try the next door.

◆

Expect a one-drink minimum; sometimes a small cover.

◆

Arcades are cash-friendly — keep coins handy.

TOKYO

Daikanyama, Nakameguro & New York Bar

Stylish quieter Tokyo — books, riverside walks, boutiques, and a cinematic nightcap.

STAY Keio Plaza Hotel Tokyo

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Nakameguro is excellent for lunch and dinner — pick by vibe. Starbucks Reserve Roastery for coffee theater.

ITINERARY

01

Daikanyama T-Site

Tsutaya bookstore complex

Elegant neighborhood with design shops and the iconic Tsutaya. Nearby Starbucks Reserve Roastery Tokyo is a multi-floor coffee landmark overlooking Meguro River.

CULTURE

02

Meguro River & Nakameguro

Local, stylish, walkable

Canal promenade, independent boutiques, bakeries, and intimate restaurants. Ideal unstructured wandering day.

FOOD

03

New York Bar — Park Hyatt Tokyo

Lost in Translation rooftop

Panoramic views, polished cocktails, sometimes live jazz. Smart-casual dress; short waits are common. A perfect Tokyo finale before Hakone.

MUST-SEE

➤

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Daikanyama (~30m): Fukutoshin to Daikan-yama.

2

Continue on foot along Meguro River to Nakameguro.

3

Return (~25m), then ~10m walk to New York Bar.

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Send large bags ahead to Kyoto tomorrow; travel light to Hakone.

◆

Hotel Musse Kyoto Shijo-Kawaramachi Meitetsu is your Kyoto base.

◆

Take this day slowly — it's designed for atmosphere.

HAKONE

Onsen country — art, volcano & Lake Ashi

Leave the megacity for mountains, open-air sculpture, volcanic Owakudani, a pirate-ship cruise, and Hakone Shrine.

STAY Hotel Kajikaso

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Black eggs and black ice cream at Owakudani; hotel dinner may include kaiseki/onsen-ryokan style — a cultural food highlight.

ITINERARY

01

Hakone Open-Air Museum

Sculpture in the mountains

Outdoor sculptures against valley views, plus indoor galleries. Easy to spend calm hours combining art and mountain air.

CULTURE

02

Owakudani

Active volcanic valley

Sulfur vents and hot springs. On clear days, Mt. Fuji appears. Taste the famous black eggs.

MUST-SEE

03

Lake Ashi Cruise & Hakone Shrine

Pirate ship + lakeside torii

Sightseeing “pirate” ship across Lake Ashinoko, then Hakone Shrine’s forest setting and dramatic red torii — including one standing in the water.

MUST-SEE

>

GETTING AROUND

1

Shinjuku → Hakone-Yumoto (~1h 45m): Romancecar.

2

Hotel → Open-Air Museum (~25m by bus).

3

Museum → Owakudani (~30m); Owakudani → Togendai by ropeway.

4

Pirate ship to Moto-Hakone → shrine; bus back to hotel.

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Start early — Hakone transfers take time.

◆

If behind schedule, skip the Open-Air Museum.

◆

Enjoy the onsen at Hotel Kajikaso in the evening — rinse first, no swimsuits in traditional baths.

KYOTO

Arrive Kyoto — markets, Gion & Pontocho

Shinkansen to Kyoto, then Nishiki Market grazing and lantern-lit Gion and Pontocho.

STAY Hotel Musse Kyoto Shijo-Kawaramachi Meitetsu

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Nishiki is Kyoto's kitchen — pickles, tofu sweets, skewers, and seasonal bites as you walk.

ITINERARY

01 Travel Hakone → Kyoto

~2h 30m via Odawara Shinkansen

Hakone Tozan to Odawara, Hikari Shinkansen to Kyoto, taxi to Hotel Musse near Kawaramachi. Bags may already be waiting if you forwarded them.

02 Nishiki Market

Kyoto's pantry street

A narrow covered market of 100+ shops — seafood, sweets, knives, Kyoto specialties. About 5 minutes from the hotel.

FOOD

03 Gion & Pontocho

Geisha district · dinner alley

Best around 17:00–18:00 as lanterns light Hanamikoji and Shirakawa. Dinner in Pontocho, then stroll the Kamogawa River.

MUST-SEE

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hakone → Kyoto hotel (~2h 30m) + taxi.
- 2 Hotel → Nishiki: ~5m walk; Nishiki → Gion: ~10m walk.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Everything tonight is walkable — rest as needed after transit.
- ◆ Be respectful photographing in Gion — no chasing geisha/maiko.

KYOTO

Arashiyama bamboo & temples

West Kyoto's classic day: bridge views, bamboo grove, monkey park, and Tenryu-ji's Zen garden.

STAY Hotel Musse Kyoto Shijo-Kawaramachi Meitetsu

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Street snacks near Togetsukyo; yudofu (hot tofu) is a local Arashiyama classic if you want a sit-down lunch.

ITINERARY

01 Togetsukyo Bridge & Bamboo Grove MUST-SEE

Arashiyama icons
The famous bridge area plus the towering bamboo path. Arrive early for softer light and fewer people.

02 Iwatayama Monkey Park PARK

Hilltop Kyoto panorama
About 20 minutes uphill (¥600). Japanese macaques roam freely; feed them only from inside the designated hut. Views over Kyoto are excellent.

03 Tenryu-ji Temple CULTURE

UNESCO Zen landscape garden
A major Rinzai Zen temple with one of Japan's finest borrowed-scenery gardens — quiet contrast after the bamboo crowds.

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hotel → Arashiyama (~35m): Hankyu via Katsura.
- 2 Return by JR San-In to Kyoto Station, then taxi/subway to hotel.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Leave before 08:00 for the bamboo grove.
- ◆ Good shoes and water for the monkey-park climb.
- ◆ Keep distance from monkeys and follow park rules.

KYOTO

Fushimi Inari, Uji & tea ceremony

Thousand vermillion torii, Uji's matcha world, Byodo-in, then a traditional tea ceremony.

STAY Hotel Musse Kyoto Shijo-Kawaramachi Meitetsu

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Uji is matcha heaven — soft serve, sweets, and tea soba along the river and Omotesando.

ITINERARY

01

Fushimi Inari Taisha

Torii tunnel mountain paths

Japan's most iconic shrine experience. Walk the first crowded gates or continue higher for quieter trails and city views. Fox messengers of Inari appear throughout.

MUST-SEE

02

Uji Bridge, Omotesando & Byodo-in

Matcha capital · Phoenix Hall

Historic bridge, tea shops, and UNESCO Byodo-in — the Phoenix Hall on Japan's ¥10 coin. A calmer, greener half-day after Fushimi.

FOOD

03

Tea Ceremony

MAIKOYA Karasuma Shijo

Chanoyu with matcha, precise ritual, and English explanation — a peaceful cultural anchor for the day.

CULTURE

➤

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Fushimi Inari (~25m): Keihan to Fushimi-Inari.

2

Fushimi → Uji (~30m): JR Nara Line.

3

Leave Uji ~15:00 for tea ceremony timing.

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Arrive Fushimi early — it gets extremely busy.

◆

Comfortable shoes for continuous climbing.

◆

Sip slowly in Uji; this day is about taste and atmosphere.

KYOTO

Higashiyama — stone streets & temples

Kiyomizu-dera, Sannenzaka & Ninenzaka, Yasaka Pagoda, Kodai-ji, and the tatami Starbucks.

STAY Hotel Musse Kyoto Shijo-Kawaramachi Meitetsu

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Matcha desserts and street snacks all along Sannenzaka/Ninenzaka — graze as you descend.

ITINERARY

01

Kiyomizu-dera

Wooden stage over the city

Founded 778 — vast timber terrace built without nails, panoramic views, and Otowa Waterfall's three blessing streams (choose only one).

MUST-SEE

02

Sannenzaka, Ninenzaka & Yasaka Pagoda

Old Kyoto postcard lanes

Stone streets, wooden townhouses, tea shops, and one of Japan's most photographed pagoda views — magical near sunset.

MUST-SEE

03

Kodai-ji & Higashiyama wander

Zen gardens · optional tatami Starbucks

A calmer Zen temple with gardens and bamboo. Then simply wander. Optional: Starbucks Ninenzaka in a century-old wooden house with tatami seating.

CULTURE

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hotel → Kiyomizu (~25m): City Bus 207.
- 2 Most sites are 5-10 minutes apart on foot.
- 3 Return by bus 207 or taxi.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Arrive Kiyomizu early.
- ◆ Hills and stairs all day — good shoes essential.
- ◆ Stay into dusk for the best lantern atmosphere.

KYOTO

Golden Pavilion & classic north Kyoto

Must-see Kinkaku-ji, a Zen rock garden or Nijo Castle, then a freer Kyoto afternoon for food and browsing.

STAY Hotel Musse Kyoto Shijo-Kawaramachi Meitetsu

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Nishiki revisit for specialties you skipped; evening kaiseki or casual izakaya near Kawaramachi.

ITINERARY

01 Kinkaku-ji (Golden Pavilion)

Japan's most famous temple view

A shimmering gold pavilion reflected in a mirror pond — one of the essential first-timer images of Japan. Go earlier for softer crowds and better photos.

MUST-SEE

02 Ryoan-ji or Nijo Castle

Choose your culture chapter

Ryoan-ji: the iconic Zen rock garden of raked gravel and stones. Or Nijo Castle: Tokugawa palace architecture and “nightingale” floors. Both are outstanding; pick by mood.

CULTURE

03 Free Kyoto afternoon

Shopping · cafés · second looks

Return south for shopping around Shijo/Kawaramachi, another Nishiki tasting lap, or simply sit by the Kamogawa with a drink. Luggage tip: forward bags to Osaka tonight/tomorrow.

FOOD

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hotel → Kinkaku-ji: bus ~40–50m (or taxi).
- 2 Kinkaku-ji → Ryoan-ji: short bus/taxi.
- 3 Return to central Kyoto by bus.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Kinkaku-ji is very popular — earlier is better.
- ◆ Forward luggage to Cross Hotel Osaka before Hiroshima.
- ◆ Keep tomorrow's transfer bags light.

HIROSHIMA

Hiroshima — garden calm & Peace Memorial

Shinkansen west to Hiroshima: Shukkeien Garden, then Peace Park and Museum. Optional Nagarekawa evening.

STAY Daiwa Roynet Hotel Hiroshima

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Hiroshima-style okonomiyaki is mandatory — layered cabbage, noodles, and savory batter on a teppan.

ITINERARY

01 Travel Kyoto → Hiroshima

~2h 30m Nozomi Shinkansen
Taxi to Kyoto Station, Nozomi to Hiroshima, tram to Chuden-mae, walk to Daiwa Roynet Hotel.

02 Shukkeien Garden

Miniature landscape garden
A classical stroll garden of “shrunk scenery.” Walk the pond loop slowly — a gentle landing in the city.

CULTURE

03 Peace Memorial Park & Museum

A-Bomb Dome · testimony · remembrance
Dome, Children’s Peace Monument, Cenotaph, Peace Flame, and a powerful museum. Allow 1.5–2 hours. Essential, emotional, unforgettable.

MUST-SEE

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Kyoto → hotel (~2h 30m + tram).
- 2 Hotel → Shukkeien / Peace Park: short taxi hops (~10m each).

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Give the museum real time — don’t rush it.
- ◆ Okonomiyaki for dinner helps settle a heavy afternoon.
- ◆ Nagarekawa nightlife is optional if energy remains.

HIROSHIMA

Miyajima Island day

Floating torii, island snacks, and Mt. Misen views — one of Japan’s most beautiful day trips.

STAY Daiwa Roynet Hotel Hiroshima

TODAY’S FOOD FOCUS Momiji manju maple cakes, fresh oysters (season), and grilled conger eel along Omotesando.

ITINERARY

01

Omotesando Shopping Street

Island food & souvenirs

About 350m of shops leading to the shrine — wooden rice paddles, maple-leaf cakes, and seafood stalls.

FOOD

02

Itsukushima Shrine

Visit at high tide and low tide if you can

The world-famous “floating” torii and shrine on stilts. High tide = classic floating look; low tide = walk near the gate. Check tide times in advance.

MUST-SEE

03

Mt. Misen

Ropeway + summit hike

Island high point with Seto Inland Sea panoramas. Ropeway up, then extra walking to viewpoints. See Reikado’s eternal flame tradition.

PARK

➤

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Miyajimaguchi (~55m): tram + JR.

2

Ferry ~10m; island sights mostly on foot + ropeway.

3

Return same way (~50m to hotel after ferry).

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Leave early to beat island crowds.

◆

Check tide tables — it changes the shrine experience.

◆

Good shoes for Misen’s extra climb beyond the ropeway.

OSAKA

Osaka arrival — markets, castle, neon

Shinkansen to Osaka, Kuromon Market grazing, Osaka Castle, then Dotonbori under your hotel.

STAY Cross Hotel Osaka

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Kuromon snacks by day; takoyaki, okonomiyaki, and kushikatsu in Dotonbori by night.

ITINERARY

01 Travel Hiroshima → Osaka
~2h 30m to Namba / Cross Hotel
Nozomi to Shin-Osaka, Midosuji Line to Namba, walk to Cross Hotel Osaka — brilliantly placed for food nights.

02 Kuromon Market
Osaka's kitchen
~600m covered market of fish, meat, produce, and sweets. Arrive hungry and graze.

03 Osaka Castle
History museum + parkland
A landmark of Japan's unification era with museum exhibits and broad castle grounds for walking and photos.

04 Dotonbori
Glico sign · street-food neon
Osaka's most famous night strip — only ~5 minutes from the hotel. Eat, photograph, and wander without a rigid plan.

FOOD

CULTURE

MUST-SEE

➤ GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hiroshima → hotel (~2h 30m).
- 2 Hotel → Kuromon: ~15m walk.
- 3 Kuromon → Castle (~35m subway); Castle → hotel (~40m).
- 4 Hotel → Dotonbori: ~5m walk.

! RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Rest at the hotel before Dotonbori.
- ◆ Castle grounds are larger than they look.
- ◆ Tonight is about tasting Osaka's loud, delicious personality.

OSAKA

Universal Studios Japan

Full amusement-park day — Super Nintendo World, Harry Potter, and Hollywood thrill rides.

STAY Cross Hotel Osaka

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Park food is fun (butterbeer, themed snacks). Evening ramen back near Namba if you leave hungry for “real” Osaka.

ITINERARY

01

Universal Studios Japan

Full park day

One of Asia’s best theme parks. Super Nintendo World is a standout (express/area entry strategy helps). Arrive at opening and prioritize headliners.

PARK

02

Evening wind-down in Namba

Easy food near the hotel

After park legs give out, keep dinner simple near Cross Hotel — Dotonbori is right there if you still want neon.

FOOD

➤

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → USJ: subway to Universal City Station (~25–35m).

2

Return same way.

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Buy tickets + Express Pass strategy in advance if possible.

◆

Nintendo World may need timed entry — check current rules.

◆

Same park-day kit: charger, sunscreen, rain layer, comfy shoes.

OSAKA

Nara deer park & Shinsekai

Day trip to Nara’s temples and friendly deer, then retro Shinsekai back in Osaka.

STAY Cross Hotel Osaka

TODAY’S FOOD FOCUS Try kakinoha-zushi in Nara; Nakatanidou fresh mochi; kushikatsu in Shinsekai at night.

ITINERARY

01 Nara Park & Todai-ji

MUST-SEE

Deer · Great Buddha · Kasuga Taisha
Free-roaming sacred deer, Todai-ji’s enormous bronze Buddha, Kasuga Taisha’s lanterns, and optional garden stops (Yoshikien / Isuien). Magical for first-timers.

02 Nakatanidou Mochi

FOOD

Lightning-fast mochi pounding
Watch (and taste) freshly pounded mochi — a fun cultural food moment if timing lines up.

03 Shinsekai & Tsutenkaku

FOOD

Retro Osaka night
Nostalgic streets under Tsutenkaku Tower — old-school arcades, street food, and a local vibe very different from Dotonbori.

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hotel → Nara (~45m): Kintetsu Rapid Express from Osaka-Namba.
- 2 Nara → Shinsekai (~55m); Shinsekai → hotel (~25m).

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Leave for Nara by 08:00–08:30.
- ◆ Deer crackers are fun — guard bags and maps.
- ◆ If tired, shorten temples or skip Shinsekai.

OSAKA

Arcade shopping & Umeda views

Japan’s longest covered shopping street, then panoramic views from Umeda Sky Building.

STAY Cross Hotel Osaka

TODAY’S FOOD FOCUS Local lunch along Tenjinbashi-suji — takoyaki, croquettes (Nakamura-ya), cheap tasty set meals.

ITINERARY

01 Tenjinbashi-suji Shopping Street

FOOD

Japan’s longest arcade (~2.6 km)
Hundreds of local shops from tea and knives to snack stalls. Start near Osaka Tenmangu Shrine, then wander north.

02 Umeda Sky Building

MUST-SEE

Floating Garden Observatory
Twin towers linked at the 39th floor with indoor and open-air city panoramas — one of Osaka’s best views.

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hotel → Tenjinbashi-suji (~25m): Sakaisuji Line to Ogimachi.
- 2 Arcade → Umeda Sky (~20m); return to Namba (~30m).

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Seek small local shops, not only chains.
- ◆ Passport for tax-free purchases.
- ◆ Great lighter day after Nara and USJ.

OSAKA

Osaka food & culture deep dive

A flexible favorite day: Instant Ramen Museum, aquarium or Den Den Town, and one last Dotonbori feast.

STAY Cross Hotel Osaka

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Design your own Cup Noodle; later chase any Osaka bites you still haven't tried.

ITINERARY

01 Momofuku Ando Instant Ramen Museum

Ikeda · make your own Cup Noodle

Fun, family-friendly food museum in Ikeda where you design and take home your own Cup Noodle. Perfect for food lovers and a memorable souvenir.

FOOD

02 Choose your afternoon

Kaiyukan · Den Den Town · Hozenji

Osaka Aquarium Kaiyukan (one of the world's great aquariums), Den Den Town for electronics/anime, or atmospheric Hozenji Yokocho alley for mossy shrine charm and quieter dining.

PARK

03 Final Osaka night

Dotonbori or hidden alleys

One last neon food crawl — or a nicer sit-down dinner if you want a calmer send-off before Tokyo.

FOOD

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hotel → Instant Ramen Museum (Ikeda): ~40–50m by Hankyu.
- 2 Afternoon option depends on choice (Kaiyukan is Tempozan area).

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Ramen Museum can queue — go earlier.
- ◆ Forward or pack carefully for tomorrow's Tokyo shinkansen.
- ◆ Keep tomorrow morning realistic — it's a transit day.

TOKYO

Return to Tokyo — Ginza ease

Shinkansen back to Tokyo. Soft landing in Ginza/Marunouchi after Osaka's intensity.

STAY Solaria Nishitetsu Hotel

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Ginza sushi, department-store depachika food halls, or a simple celebratory dinner.

ITINERARY

01 Travel Osaka → Tokyo

~3h 20m Nozomi to Ginza area

Midosuji to Shin-Osaka, Nozomi Shinkansen, then local line to Higashi-ginza and Solaria Nishitetsu Hotel.

02 Marunouchi & Ginza at your pace

Architecture · shopping · cafés

All walkable from the hotel. Explore depachika basement food halls — one of Japan's great culinary treasures for first-timers.

FOOD

➤ GETTING AROUND

- 1 Osaka → Tokyo hotel (~3h 20m).
- 2 Afternoon sights are walking distance.

! RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Keep the day easy after transit.
- ◆ Depachika (department basement) is perfect for picnic-style dinner items.
- ◆ Check sumo ticket availability for tomorrow.

TOKYO

Sumo culture day (Aki basho season)

September often brings Tokyo’s Autumn Grand Sumo Tournament — a bucket-list cultural experience if tickets are available.

STAY Solaria Nishitetsu Hotel

TODAY’S FOOD FOCUS Chanko nabe (sumo stew) in Ryogoku; otherwise classic Tokyo lunch near the arena.

ITINERARY

01

Grand Sumo at Ryogoku Kokugikan

Book ahead if possible

If the Autumn tournament is on, spend an afternoon at the stadium — rituals, pageantry, and explosive matches. Even a few hours is unforgettable. If sold out, visit the Sumo Museum area and watch highlights elsewhere.

MUST-SEE

02

Ryogoku neighborhood

Sumo stables district · Edo-Tokyo Museum

Wander Ryogoku’s sumo-town atmosphere. The Edo-Tokyo Museum (confirm open/status) or nearby history spots deepen the cultural day.

CULTURE

03

Backup plan if no sumo tickets

Shimokitazawa or Tokyo Disneyland

Option A: Shimokitazawa for vintage shops and indie cafés. Option B: Tokyo Disneyland as a second park day if you want more rides after DisneySea.

PARK

>

GETTING AROUND

1

Hotel → Ryogoku: ~25–35m by subway.

2

Return to Ginza area in the evening.

!

RECOMMENDATIONS

◆

Sumo tickets can sell out — check official channels early.

◆

Tournament days run long; afternoon sessions are popular with visitors.

◆

No-show backup keeps the day excellent either way.

TOKYO

Last full day — favorites & shopping

A flexible finale: revisit a favorite neighborhood, finish gifts, and bookend the trip with something you loved most.

STAY Solaria Nishitetsu Hotel

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Return to a favorite meal — sushi, ramen, or izakaya. Celebrate the trip.

ITINERARY

01 Choose your encore

Build your perfect last day

Ideas: teamLab revisit vibes elsewhere, more Ginza shopping, Meiji/Harajuku again, a cookware finish in Kappabashi, or a calm museum morning (teamLab already done — maybe a craft/whisky tasting or onsen-style spa).

MUST-SEE

02 Gift & packing afternoon

KitKat flavors · snacks · last tax-free

Don Quijote and depachika are excellent for last-minute edible souvenirs. Keep liquids/food rules in mind for flights.

FOOD

03 Farewell Tokyo evening

Skyline drink or quiet dinner

A rooftop/bar with a view, or a quiet sushi counter — your call. Pack tonight so tomorrow morning stays calm.

FOOD

GETTING AROUND

- 1 Depends on your encore choice — Ginza base makes many options easy.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Confirm Narita transfer timing for tomorrow evening flight.
- ◆ Set aside passports, tickets, and a personal-item kit tonight.
- ◆ Don't overschedule — leave space to enjoy.

TOKYO

Tsukiji morning & Narita departure

One last Tokyo breakfast at Tsukiji Outer Market, then evening departure from Narita.

STAY Departure day

TODAY'S FOOD FOCUS Final Tsukiji feast — make it count.

ITINERARY

01 Tsukiji Outer Market

FOOD

Last breakfast in Japan
Return for a final graze — tamagoyaki, sashimi bowls, grilled seafood. A delicious full-circle goodbye if you loved Day 5.

02 Hotel · pack · airport transfer

Evening departure from Narita
Return to collect luggage, then transfer to Narita with generous buffer. Aim to be at the airport well ahead of your flight (often 22:30-style evening departures need an early-evening leave from central Tokyo).

➤ GETTING AROUND

- 1 Hotel/Tsukiji → Narita: allow 2.5–3+ hours door-to-gate.
- 2 Private transfer is easiest with luggage.

! RECOMMENDATIONS

- ◆ Eat first, pack second, airport third.
- ◆ Keep yen for last snacks and station/airport purchases.
- ◆ Say goodbye properly — Japan rewards unhurried endings.